Compare Two LIS Databases (Application)

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SLIS 6115: Information and Inquiry

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15 July 2025

Purpose, Scope, and Intended Audience

LISTA

The *Library, Information Science and Technology Abstracts (LISTA)* database provides indexing and abstracting of hundreds of journals, books, research reports, and conference proceedings. According to UI Libraries' Lib Guide page, *Library and Information Science: Core Resources*, the scope of the LISTA database contains resources for library and information science studies and reaches from 1966 to the present. Some peer-reviewed and full-text resources are available. According to EBSCO, the purpose of the database is to provide these resources to its intended audience, which includes library and information science professionals, researchers, and students.

LISA

The *Library and Information Science Abstracts (LISA)* database is an abstracting and indexing tool designed for library professionals and other information specialists. According to the Proquest product page, LISA "abstracts over 440 periodicals from more than 68 countries and in more than 20 different languages." In addition to abstracts, full-text resources, and peer-reviewed materials from around the world, LISA's scope encompasses a variety of subjects, including information management and technology, library and archival studies, and digital communications and retrieval.

Types of Sources Indexed

	LISTA	**LISA**
Source Type	Source database (contains links to actual sources, not	Source database (contains links to actual sources, not

	just abstracts or metadata) journals, books, research reports, conference proceedings	just abstracts or metadata) periodicals
Genre	Texts, focused on LIS practice areas	Texts
Selection Principle	Subject-specific content for library and information science	Subject-specific content for library and information science
Form of Information	Research Database, specifically Abstracting & Indexing (A&I)	Research Database, specifically A&I

Both databases cover aspects of library management and the role of librarians as well as publishing, cataloging and classification, and information retrieval; LISTA specifically calls out electronic searching on its EBSCO product page. Some subjects that appear to be unique to LISA include artificial intelligence, information technology and internet technology, knowledge management, and telecommunications and technical services. Areas of focus that appear to be unique to LISTA include care and restoration of books, rare books and circulation procedures, censorship. and copyright. While both databases cover essential aspects of library and information science, LISA has seems to have a stronger emphasis on technology and modern

information management practices, whereas LISTA appears more focused on traditional library operations and preservation issues.

Search Interfaces

LISTA

The LISTA search interface offers three search bars with the option to add rows. The search bars are connected by drop-down menus of boolean terms, and each search bar can be customized with an additional drop-down menu to search all fields or to narrow a search term to one of the following:

- All Text
- Author
- Title
- Subject Terms
- Abstract or Author-Supplied Abstract
- Author-Supplied Key Words
- Geographic Terms
- People
- Reviews & Products
- Company Entity
- Publication Name
- ISSN (No dashes)
- ISBN
- Accession Number

Filters below the search bars allow users to restrict searches to linked full text, references, and peer review as well as publication date, publication type, document type, language, and more.

LISA

The LISA database search interface offers two search bars with the option to add rows. The search bars are separated by a drop-down menu of boolean terms, and each search bar can be customized with an additional drop-down menu to search anywhere or to narrow a search term to one of the following:

- Anywhere except full text
- Abstracts
- All abstracts & summary text
- All subjects and indexing (with sub-options like location, company name, person)
- Author
- Document title
- Publication title (with sub-options like publisher and ISBN)

Filters below the search fields allow users to limit their search results to peer-reviewed items as well as to filter results by publication date, source type, document type, and language. Interestingly, the top of the LISA search page provides links to search using command line or using the thesaurus.

The search interfaces and available search options of both databases are pretty similar at first glance. The EBSCOHost interface for LISTA includes many more drop-down menus for filtering search results while the ProQuest interface for LISA features many more check boxes for filtering. If LISTA offers command line searching, it was not easy to locate. LISTA seems to provide more specific search field types than LISA.

Suitability of Databases for Particular Research Questions

To test the suitability of the LISA and LISTA databases, the following research questions were explored:

1. What are the impacts of restorative justice practices on teen engagement with the public library?
2. How can public library staff enforce rules and expectations safely without involving police?

For research question #1, LISA is the more appropriate choice due to its focus on scholarly and policy-oriented sources in library and information science. Restorative justice is both a social justice framework and a behavioral intervention method, so this question intersects library practice with social policy. LISA's international coverage may include in-depth studies and global case studies that explore this topic. Running a cursory search of the keywords from the research question in LISA yielded 33 results; the same search in LISTA yielded only two results. The search results in LISA appear more focused on critical analysis while the LISTA results seem to offer descriptive accounts of restorative justice in practice. LISA provides a breakdown of number of search results by source type in the left-side navigation bar, which is a nice feature. Both databases may lack intersectional analysis of restorative justice practices with teens compared to sources in educational databases, for example, where restorative justice practices have been studied for longer periods of time and with wider populations.

For research question #2, LISTA is the better choice. Running some quick searches using key concepts from the research question revealed that the research question needs some fine-tuning. Search results were either non-existent or wildly varying in relevance for both LISA and LISTA, but LISTA did return some relevant search results using its SmartText Searching

feature (for which an explanation could not be found). Most of the results were trade publications, aligning with this question's focus on the practical needs of frontline library staff, such as real-world implementation of safety and de-escalation policies and practices. Neither database appears to include much interdisciplinary research on policing, public space, or trauma-informed care. Supplementing this research question with criminal justice or social work databases could improve the depth and context of sources.

In summary, LISA seems like a more academically-oriented database with its inclusion of scholarly journals, dissertations, and theses that provide library and information science topics from theoretical and global perspectives. LISTA seems to be more practice-focused, returning content written for working librarians, such as trade journals. However, there is some overlap of these source types in both databases. LISA might be a better option for students and researchers, while LISTA might be the better option for working professionals in library and information settings. Users should choose based on the goals of their inquiry: theory or practice. Of course, the best approach may be to use both databases in conjunction to maximize search results.

References

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